didn’t want the rhythm of the meeting to be broken. They answered him with a polite ‘No sir, thank you’.

The IB chief continued to inform the PM that Rajiv’s message was conveyed to Kittu—arms had to be dropped before any peace talk could take place through the foreign office and R&AW. But a clear message like that from Rajiv had upset the LTTE. They understood that the former Indian PM would come down heavy on the Tamil Tigers if he came back to power. There was a wireless message sometime in the latter part of March from the LTTE’s intelligence chief Pottu Amman to one ‘Jack’ to get ready for Delhi and send ‘black tigress Gowri’ along with ‘Uncle’ to the Indian capital as backup.

The PM felt it all sounded like a John le Carré thriller. He could not believe that the agencies had sat over so much ‘intel’ and still done nothing.

There was silence in the room until Karan spoke again. The CBI suspected the LTTE had been at it for quite some time. The question was whether they had finally succeeded in Sriperumbudur. He assured the PM that the SIT would not spare any angle or any clue from investigation; any information that was received, even if it appeared inconsequential on the surface, would be probed. The meeting ended on an encouraging note as the PM showed complete confidence in both. Narayanan was personally very close to Rajiv Gandhi, so he looked somewhat emotional towards the end of the meeting. It didn’t go unnoticed by the PM. He turned to Narayanan and said that death came to everyone—whether it came with inner dignity and honour, or was just a pitiful incident depended on how people lived their lives at that particular moment. The PM saw both of them off to the door.

Anirudhya’s next stop was Malligai, where the SIT office was located. He was not looking into barging into an office where some of his best contacts and friends had been busy trying to crack the most controversial crime in Indian history. He had taken an appointment with Kaarthikeyan, who, over the phone, had promised only five minutes as he was ‘not yet authorized to